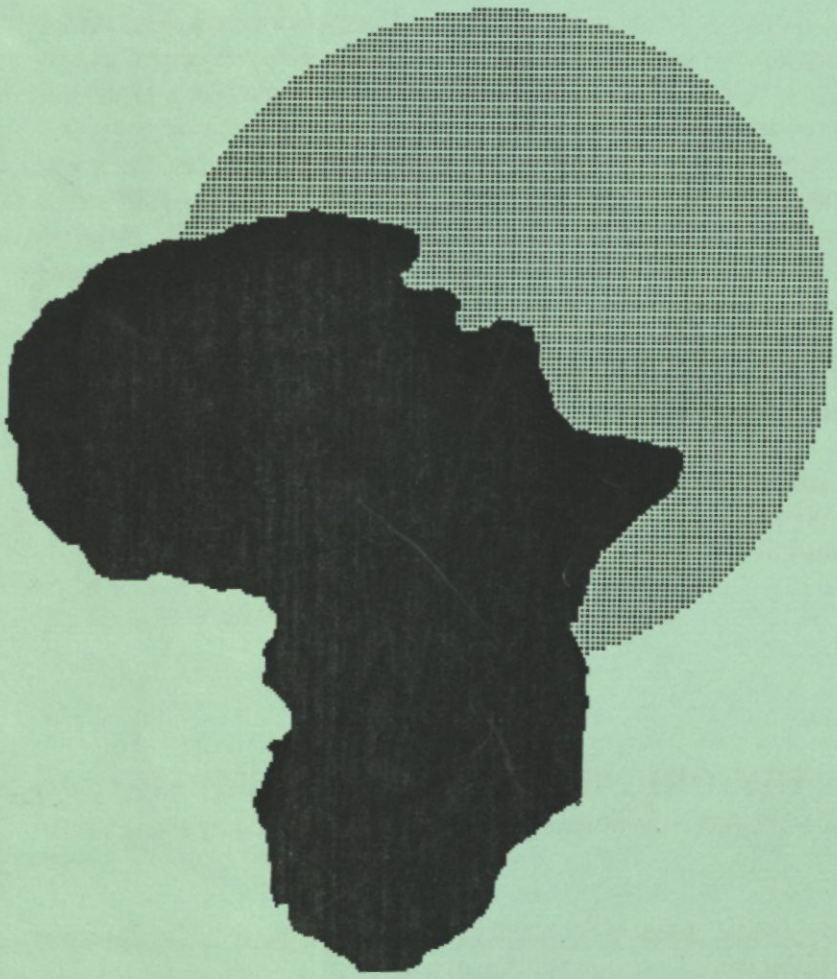
African Sun

November, 1991



Corrections for October, '91 African Sun:

We apologize for the mistakes, but Professor Fayneese Miller was the third, not the fourth woman of color to receive tenure at Brown University.

November 11, 1991

Dear (Literary/Visual) Artists,

Thank you for submitting your art to Uwezo Black Arts Magazine. A new Uwezo policy has been implemented to privilege the "objective" examination of and discussion about your work of art where each piece was considered anonymously.

Copies of Uwezo should be available in early December. There will be a second '91-'92 publication second semester. It is the Uwezo staff's hope that you will submit new work for the second semester publication. If you are planning to submit new work next semester, please remember to start planning your art production/creation processes early.

If at any time you have questions or concerns about some aspect of Uwezo, please contact me (X5874, Box 2493) Ama Shulman (X4459, Box 4335), or Kenya Brome (X5141, Box 3816).

Very Sincerely,
Jackie Wigfall
Editor-in-Chief, Uwezo, '91-'92

HISTORICAL EVENTS IN NOVEMBER

1, 1945—The first issue of *Ebony* magazine was published by John H. Johnson.

3, 1868—John W. Menard became the first Black person elected to Congress. He was later denied a seat in the House.

8, 1938—The first Black woman legislator, Crystal Bird Fauset of Philadelphia, was elected to the Pennsylvania legislature.

9, 1731—Benjamin Banneker, a Black inventor and scientist, was born in Ellicott's Mills, Maryland.

12, 1775—General Washington issued orders which forbade officers to recruit or enlist Blacks.

12, 1922—Sigma Gamma Rho Sorority, Inc. was founded at Butler University, in Indianapolis, Indiana.

14, 1915—Booker T. Washington, an educator and organizer, died at age 59 in Tuskegee, Alabama.

29, 1961—The Freedom Riders were attacked by a white mob in a bus station at McComb, Mississippi.

Blacks at Brown

19, 1968—The Cammarian Club (Brown's Student Government) discussed whether the Afro-American Society (est. 1967) was racist because it held closed meetings and did not allow white students to join the organization.

1891—John Wesley Gilbert became the first Black student to receive a Masters Degree at Brown.

Source: Lerone Bennet Jr. Before the Mayflower 1982
Brown Daily Herald, Timeline of Third World History at Brown

NEWS

AFRICA

Zambia

In Zambia's first democratic presidential elections in nearly two decades, Kenneth Kaunda suffered a landslide defeat to his main opposition leader, Frederick Chiluba. Kenneth Kaunda led Zambia since its independence nineteen years ago. He bequeaths to Chiluba a bankrupt country.

Zaire

Zaire continues in its slide into total anarchy, following the renewedoutburst of violence which has engulfed the entire country. The violence erupted in the wake of the sacking of the Prime Minister Etienne Tshisekedi five days after his appointment. He was President Mobutu's main opposition leader. As the crisis worsens the demands for introducing democracy have been more strident. Belgium, France and the US have pressured President Mobutu to seek a compromise with his opposition. Mobutu stands aloof and refuses to succumb to external pressure.

South Africa

After having been banned from international competition for 21 years, South Africa's cricket team played in their first international match on Sunday, November 10 in India where they received a warm welcome. Although sanctions against South Africa have been lifted, the situations for Blacks in South Africa have not changed substantially.

U.S. and Africa

The U.S. government has waived payments of debts totaling more than $16 million owed by Uganda. The relief was granted for the least developed countries undertaking positive economic measures in connection with the IMF or WORLD BANK. Ghana, Malawi, Madagascar, Senegal and Tanzania will also benefit.

Sources: West Africa
British Broadcasting Corporation (News Desk).

AFRO-SOUTH AMERICA

The president of Brasil, Fernando Collor de Mello, just returned from his tour of Africa in September. His visit included Angola, Zimbabwe, Mozambique and Namibia. Collor is the first non-African head of state to visit Namibia since it gained its independence last year. With this tour, Collor hopes to promote trade and strengthen ties with the new democracies.

Source: The Brasilians, September, 1991

UNITED STATES

Blacks, Athletics, and Racism

In its landmark 1968 study, "The Black Athlete - A Shameful Story," *Sports Illustrated* made its first significant attempt at consciousness-raising journalism by sparking a national debate on discrimination against Blacks in professional sports. Now, twenty-three years later, *Sports Illustrated* has once again taken up the issue in a three-part series titled "How Far Have We Come?" The magazine reported that Black athletes are ascending into managerial positions and are receiving higher salaries than in previous years. The study also cited more vocal challenges by Blacks against discriminatory practices in athletics, and stated that white fans, other athletes, and management are showing more sensitivity to race issues.

Black Soldiers' Memorial

In Washington, D.C., a memorial is being erected to honor the Black soldiers who fought more than one hundred years ago for the Union Army in the Civil War. Funds for the monument are being provided through both private and public donations, and the monument will include a statue and a low wall with inscriptions of the names of the more than 185,000 soldiers who fought for the Union. Said Mayor Sharon Pratt Dixon, "No one has believed in America more than African-Americans. A monument celebrating the African-American soldiers is long overdue." In addition to honoring Black soldiers, project supporters also hope that the monument will revitalize U Street, an area that was formerly the heart of Washington's Black community.

Black-Owned Newspaper Lives On

The 117-year-old *Oakland Tribune*, the only Black-owned daily newspaper singularly serving a large U.S. city, has endured financial hardships to retain its Black ownership. Robert Maynard, who purchased the Pulitzer prize-winning *Tribune* from the Gannett Company in 1983, had been struggling with the paper financially for several years and owed $31.5 million in debt to Gannett. After negotiating a new agreement, the *Tribune* will pay only $2.5 million, and Gannett will waive the remainder. The Freedom Forum, a foundation for journalism, will provide several million dollars as an operating budget for the paper. Had the *Tribune* folded, Oakland would have been the largest U.S. city without its own daily newspaper.

Source: Emerge, November 1991

CAMPUS NEWS

Welcome to Brown, ΣΓΡ

The Mu Kappa Chapter of Sigma Gamma Rho Sorority, Inc. was chartered on November 2, 1991, at Brown University. The chartering line members are **Antoinette Blanchette, Nicole Clement, Gila Hillard, Sharon Malcolm, Neneh Mbye, Kim O'Neale, and, Crystal Younge.** Founded on November 12, 1922 at Butler University in Indianapolis, Indiana by seven teachers, Sigma Gamma Rho has over 350 undergraduate and alumnae chapters in the U.S., Africa, Bermuda, and the Bahamas. Modeling their future plans after the Sigma motto—Greater Service, Greater Progress—the members are planning various community service projects. On a broader scale, the Sigmas are involved in two major projects: Project Africa and Project Reassurance. The purpose of Project Africa is to raise money to buy agricultural products for African women, while the purpose of Project Reassurance is to provide health education for pregnant adolescents and teens. This sorority promises to contribute further diversity to the Brown community.

Sisters United Making a Difference

Black women, are you out there? Are you concerned about your fellow sisters? Does unity exist for you? No? Are you ready to make a change? You can make a difference. And that is exactly what these women did on November 4, in Petteruti Lounge. The gathering marked the first meeting of Brown Sisters United, a support group for Black women on campus. Spearheaded by **Dawn Adams, Angelique Anderson, Heather Gray, Kehli Harding, Danine Lard, and Nadirah Moreland**, BSU seeks to confront the differences and conflicts that exist between Black women of different classes on campus. Some goals of the group are the implementation of a peer mentoring program for incoming female first years, academic advising, community service in Providence, and a general feeling of unity among the sisters in the Brown community.

Heightened Awareness

This month marked a time of heightened awareness within the African-American community. Seminars abounded in which brothers and sisters discussed their life experiences in an attempt to enlighten each other. In forums such as *The Black Male* and *The Black Female*, individuals voiced their problems with society and elaborated on personal experiences while pondering possible solutions. By finding a common ground, they hoped to achieve a greater sense of racial harmony, thus fortifying the community.

Brown also witnessed a plethora of events which were part of the week-long African Writers Festival. Such literary greats asNigerian Noble Laureate, Wole Soyinka and Harvard Professor, V.Y. Mudimbe or Zaire graced Brown students with their eloquent words and sage sayings. Thursday's Funk Nite was presented with an African twist as *Bolu and the Roots of Africa Percussion* from West Africa performed. Later in the week, Ghanian playwright, Amà Ata Aidoo's, *Anowa* was showcased at Rites and Reason. For many students, the week gave a glimpse of their mystic roots while for others it gave a chance to reaffirm their rich, diverse heritage.

Brown Students Mourn Fellow Student

On Sunday, November 10,1991, Brown students paid their last respects to fellow classmate Iran Bachman '93 in a memorial service held in Manning Chapel. Bachman died a few days earlier from a virus. The Brown community will miss this young man's presence.

THOUGHTS AND OPINIONS

To the dogged colored boys-
Who have considered suicide when they couldn't get enough pussy.

Colored boys, we need to talk:
You say that you are "...so tired of sistas moaning and groaning
About how the Black man has oppressed the Black woman."
How dare you belittle the Black woman's struggles.
This oppression is a fact.
Yes, we have the right to have an attitude!
We bear your children.
We put up with your shit--daily.
We overlook the many wrongs that you have committed against us-
Because we love you.

I am one of those women who likes "pretty boys", athletic bodies and men that are not "good" for me.
I am not saying that I wouldn't give a nice guy a chance
But...
I will not apologize for my taste in men.

Do not deceive yourself- you are not free from guilt.
You commit the same crimes that you accuse us of:
Pursuing certain types of women: the "bitches", the fly girls and the boomin' body sistas.
Why do you keep chasing femme fatales

That occasionally throw you a bone,
And diss the good sistas who might not give you none?

So think about this
Before you call me bitch—
When you're the one IN HEAT.
--An Honest Black Woman

Black Beauty

During the summer I had an interesting conversation with a thirteen year old girl from home, Brooklyn, New York. I remember listening to her talk about her frustrations with her "short nappy hair". She said that she didn't have that "good hair" like "some of those white people". This same girl refuses to go to the beach or wear shorts during the summer because her mother told her that she would get "blacker...and ain't nobody want that". She is not the only one.

Yesterday I met a woman, here at Brown, who reminded me of this little girl. She too was frustrated with her black body. She too had the "curse of a black woman". She could not be content with her "big behind, fatty thighs, and large feet". It is to these two friends and other sisters out there that I dedicate this poem.

No Images
She does not know
Her beauty,
She thinks her brown body
Has no glory.

If she could dance
Naked,
Under palm trees.
And see her image in the river
she would know.

But there are no palm trees
On the street,
And dish water gives back no images.

-Waring Cuney

Beauty has been in the eyes of white society. Love us brothers, and yourselves sisters, enough to challenge those conceptions! Take time to remind those black women around you that their black bodies do have glory!

—Wendy Maragh

THE BLACK COMMUNITY'S GUIDE TO UNDERSTANDING THE BLACK GAY MALE

For many of my adolescent years, I agonized over the fact that I was attracted to other males. I wanted to be "normal" like the rest of my male friends. I did not want to be one of "them"—a faggot, a pervert, a punk. But eventually I accepted my sexuality and in doing so I accepted myself. Since my self-acceptance, however, I have had to deal with the fact that, while I have accepted and acknowledged my sexuality, society has not. More troublesome is the fact that my own people, the African-American community, have been oppressive and critical of my sexuality. This criticism is expressed not overtly or directly, but in subtle ways—through glances that convey the message "I don't like what you represent," and during awkward moments in groups of people when it is declared silently that "we feel uncomfortable around you." Although not every person in the Black community has reacted this way, a large segment of the Black community seems to believe that a Black man being gay is simply unacceptable. One basic reason for this ethos, I have concluded, is that the Black community does not understand what it means for a Black man to be gay. Thus, in order to begin to rectify the current situation, to provide some understanding of the Black gay man, I write this piece. This piece goes to those who are confused as to why I am gay. It goes to those who feel uncomfortable around me because I am gay. It goes to those who can't take the fact that I am gay. It goes to those who condemn me behind closed doors. It goes to those who glance at me with disgusted eyes. It goes to those who act casually around me as if my sexuality does not bother them when it really does bother them. It goes to those who act fake around me, pretending to be my friend, when, in fact, they despise me. This piece goes to every member of the Black community who misunderstands and rejects Black gay sexuality.

First, you must understand that I did not choose to be gay. My being gay came as naturally to me as did my black skin. The only choice I made was to acknowledge the fact that I was gay. Even this acknowledgement, though, was more a matter of fate than one of choice. Because my sexual feelings were so strong, because my sexuality was such a tremendous and vital part of me, it was virtually impossible to decide not to acknowledge the fact that I was gay. My trying to convince myself that I was straight for the rest of my life would have been as ridiculous and self-defeating as my trying to convince myself that I was white. However, do not get the impression that being gay is a burden or plight that one is forced to endure. It is difficult, at times, being gay, mostly because it is difficult living in a homophobic society; however, I am proud to be gay and would not have it any other way.

My decision to acknowledge my sexuality was not easy, though, because I, too, used to despise gay men. I was always the most homophobic voice in any group of people. But my hatred came not from what I thought gay men represented or from what I thought they did in their bedrooms. Instead, my hatred of them was a hatred of myself, because I knew that I was one of them. It took me many years to accept my sexuality. Feelings of rage, depression, confusion, guilt,

and self-hatred were all a part of this process. This acceptance has been truly empowering, though, because it has made me a stonger person. Thus, even though your glances and your gossip trouble me, I can take it. I take it because it makes me stronger. The more you hate me, the stronger I become.

Another fact that you must understand is that even though I am attracted to men, I am not attracted to all men. To those men who feel uncomfortable around me because they think that I want them, you must realize that you are not all that. Because a man is gay does not mean that he lusts after every man he sees. It does not mean that I have to settle for whatever I can get. I have preferences, too. Furthermore, just as you can have platonic relationships with women, I can and do have friendly relationships with other men.

Finally, and most importantly, I must declare that my "gayness" does not preclude, exclude, or dilute my "blackness". The fact that I am gay does not in any way mean that I have not experienced the racism, discrimination, and oppression that are part of the Black experience. I am gay, but I am also an African-American who cares deeply about the problems of our race. Our struggle will not be successful if we are divided. By alienating and excluding gays and lesbians from the community, you are, in fact, dividing the community. You must realize that there are many gay brothers and lesbian sisters in this community. Because of the homophobic attitude of the Black community, however, many of these people are "in the closet". But, still, they exist. We are not embarrassments to the community; we are assets to the community. Instead of being troubled by the fact that there are Black students in this community who identify as gay and lesbian, you should be annoyed, as I am, that there are Black students in this community who do not care about the problems we face on and outside of this campus. The more Black students who give a damn about our race, whether these students are gay or not, the sooner we can overcome the problems that we face on this campus and in this society.

In conclusion, I advise you to not scoff at this piece and reject it as simply an angry, reactionary attack on the Black community. I do resent the way that many people in this community have reacted to my sexuality; however, I do care about my people, otherwise I would not be taking the time to address the brothers and sisters of this community. At the same time, I want to make it clear that I am not looking for you to approve of my sexuality or to validate my African-American identity. I know and love who I am, and, with or without you, I will survive and grow stronger. However, as a concerned brother, I hope that you think about the points I have raised and learn from them so that we all may work together. I hope that the Black community will overcome its fear of its gay brothers and sisters. I say you fear us because I believe that one fears what one does not understand. Hopefully, then, I have provided you with some understanding of what it means for a Black man to be gay. In return, I ask that you accept me for what I am, respect me for who I am, and acknowledge me as a African-American gay male who cares about our people.

Peace and Unity,
Lamont Anthony Gordon

The Magic of Education

Early this month, Magic Johnson was in the spotlight, but not because of a spectacular play or a championship game. On that day, Magic Johnson gave the world a double blow. He announced that he was going to retire and that he was HIV positive.

The initial response to the news was one of both shock and grief. There was a sense of loss. His leadership and his athletic ability will be missed in the sports world. However, all is not lost. Both Magic Johnson and the general public have used a potentially tragic situation in a constructive way.

One positive result was a increased awareness of the AIDS threat. Oftentimes within minority communities, AIDS is perceived as "other people's disease"—white gay males, intravenous drug users or prostitutes. If people aren't "high risk", then they give AIDS little or no thought.

Then along comes Magic Johnson, an affluent Black male who contracted the virus through unsafe sex. This drove home the reality that AIDS doesn't discriminate on the basis of race, class or sexual orientation. It has called attention to the fact that in some urban areas a large percentage of the AIDS victims are African-American. The second largest carrier of the HIV virus are African-American females. AIDS has had a devastating effect on our communities. We have become the "other people".

Magic Johnson's status as well as his openness about the disease may serve to remove some of the stigma regarding the victims. He is both highly visible and highly respected. People are able to relate to his plight and sympathize with him, rather than look at him as a danger or an aberration. He immediately shared his condition with the public, negating the view that AIDS is a shameful secret that must be hidden.

In addition, his prominence will open the debate about many other AIDS-related issues that are often ignored: How does HIV virus spread? What can be done to prevent that spread, especially among African-Americans? Was the HIV virus deliberately created? Is little being done about the HIV virus because it is seen as taking care of societies "undesirables"? What are the problems with our health care and health information systems?

Finally there is the issue of Magic Johnson. His affliction is a tragedy, but he should not be written off yet. As his fans and his community, we should support him not pity him. We should not be too quick to eulogize him, because he is still alive and well. And he still has important things to say...

—Milda Saunders, '95

EDITORS' NOTE

The thoughts and opinions you've just read do not necessarily reflect the opinions or views of The African Sun or OUAP. Although the African Sun publishes anonymous submissions, the co-editors must be informed of the author's name to validate his or her identity. **No anonymous submissions will be published without this information.**

CALENDAR OF UPCOMING EVENTS

Nov. 22—Alpha Kappa Alpha Sorority, Inc. will host a Unity Day from 4-6 pm in the TWC.

Nov. 22-24, 29-Dec. 1—Kulcha Kollectiv's play "The Owl Answers" written by Adrienne Kennedy, directed by Rhonda Ross. Fri at 8 pm, Sat. at 3, 8 pm and Sun at 4 pm in George H. Bass Memorial Auditorium.

Nov. 23—OUAP, ASA, The Afro-Am Dept., Phi Beta Sigma Fraternity, Inc., Black Pre-Meds., Pan-Hell, NAACP, SOCA and Third World Pre-Business are co-sponsoring *The Ebony Soiree*. It will be held in Alumnae Hall at 8 pm. Tickets are $5. Dress is classy casual.

Dec 4-11—"Santa's sisters" of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc. Xmas bake sale.

Dec 5—Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc. Pre-Xmas Party 10 pm-1 am St Xavier Gym at Johnson & Wales.

Dec 8—OUAP meeting, 2 pm in the TWC.

Dec 8—NAACP general meeting for new and returning members, 3 pm in Room 201 of Faunce House.

Black Evening Worship will be held Sundays at 5:30 in Manning Chapel led by new intern, Reverend Deborah Robinson Dixon. She holds office hours Tuesdays in the Chaplins' office

BPMS December meeting topic: Summer Internships; featuring Levon Parker of the National Institutes of Health. More info to follow.

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